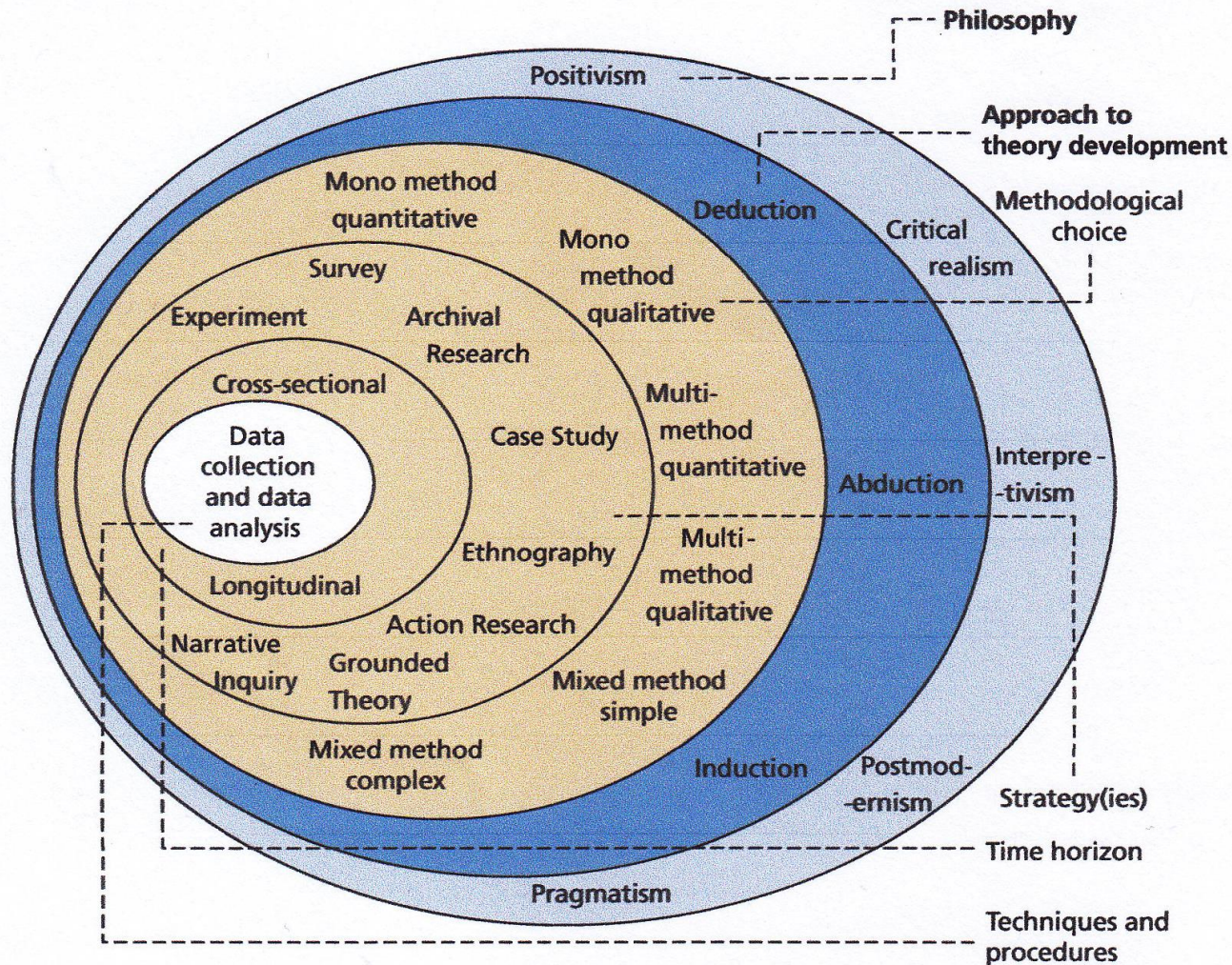


Research strategies

George Boak



Saunders et al (2019) – 'The Research Onion'

Research strategies

To test a theory or to build a theory?

Quantitative or qualitative data?

At one point in time, or over a period of time?

A fixed or a flexible data gathering strategy?

Testing a theory – a deductive strategy

Stages:

1. Develop a hypothesis from theory

eg ‘in times of change, staff who work for transformational leaders will be more satisfied than staff who work for transactional leaders’

2. Develop definitions and measurements of the key concepts

‘time of change’ ‘transformational leaders’ ‘transactional leaders’ ‘satisfaction’

3. Gather and analyse data

4. Confirm or amend the theory

Deductive approaches often (but not always) use surveys and quantitative data

Building a theory – an inductive strategy

1. Develop a research question

eg 'what satisfies and dissatisfies staff in times of change?'

2. Gather data

- find out from staff who are experiencing change what makes them satisfied or dissatisfied

3. Analyse data and develop theory

- relate your developing theory to existing, published theory

Inductive approaches use qualitative data and often (but not always) interviews

Quantitative or qualitative data?

Quantitative approaches

- gathering data that you can aggregate and analyse using statistical methods

Typical quantitative approaches:

Seek data from a large number of people

Use questionnaires with standard, closed questions
(because these are easy to aggregate)

Are concerned to show that findings are representative of the population

Qualitative approaches

- gathering and analysing qualitative data, such as things people say, or descriptions of what people do

Typically:

Use semi-structured interviews to gather data

Seek data from a relatively small number of people

Are concerned to explore what is possible in selected cases, rather than trying to show what is representative of a wider population

At one point in time – cross-sectional
or over a period of time - longitudinal?

Cross sectional

Information gathered at one point in time.
Usually by survey or structured interview, but may also have semi-structured interviews.

Longitudinal

Information gathered at more than one point in time.
May be by survey or by interview.
Usually to study processes of change.

Saunders et al (2019)

Fixed or flexible data gathering strategy?

Fixed

The design of the study is fixed before the main data collection stage. Data is usually quantitative – gathered by survey

Flexible

Design evolves during the data collection.

Data is usually qualitative.

Multi-strategy

Usually a flexible stage followed by a fixed stage

Robson and McCartan (2017)